Up in the highlands of Gilgit-Baltistan, there was a development in 1943. As described in the previous chapter, the news of Soviet troop movements and infiltration in the Hindu Kush region compelled the Government of India to take the Gilgit subdivision on lease from Maharaja Hari Singh in 1935. They merged the Gilgit sub-division with the districts of Puniyal, Koh-e-Khizr, Yasin and Yashkoman and the state of Chitral. The whole conglomeration was called the Gilgit Agency, which came under the absolute control of the political agent based in Gilgit. In 1943, Lt. Col. E. H. Cobb took over as the Political Agent and he enforced his power through an armed force of 800 men, called the Gilgit Scouts. The Commandant and all the top officers were British. In effect, the Commandant was, for all practical purposes, the military advisor to the Political Agent. The force was divided into platoons and billeted at strategic locations throughout the agency. Lt. William Brown was appointed adjutant of the scouts in 1943 and was based in Gilgit. Thereafter, he was promoted to Captain and spent one year as the Assistant Political Agent in Chilas.

The winds of change blowing through the state in 1946 saw Col. Roger Bacon OBE take over as the Political Agent in Gilgit. At the same time, Capt. William Brown was transferred to Waziristan in the NWFP in November 1946 as an officer in the Tochi Scouts. It was here that he met Jock Mathieson who was later to serve as his assistant in Gilgit.[7] Was there a hidden agenda in these seemingly routine and innocuous moves?